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2.1 Changing Spaces, Making Places

This topic explores the meaning and significance of places, how they are shaped by internal and external forces, and how places are represented, changed, and managed. It requires you to study your own local place and a contrasting place in depth, using both quantitative and qualitative evidence. Central to this topic is the idea that places are not fixed or natural — they are socially constructed, experienced differently by different people, and constantly evolving.

What Is a Place?

Place: A location with meaning. Places are not just physical locations — they are given identity and significance by human experiences, perceptions, attachments, and social processes. A space becomes a place when people ascribe meaning to it through experience, memory, and social interaction (Yi-Fu Tuan's distinction between abstract "space" and meaningful "place").

Space: A physical area without assigned meaning or emotional attachment. It is abstract, measurable, and geometrical.
Sense of place: The subjective, emotional attachment and meaning people feel towards a place, shaped by personal experience, memory, identity, and social relationships. It is deeply personal — two people living on the same street may have very different senses of place.
Spirit of place (genius loci): The distinctive atmosphere or character of a place that makes it feel unique — often hard to quantify but immediately recognisable.
Placelessness: Places that lack unique identity or character, often due to globalisation and standardisation. Edward Relph (1976) argued that mass culture, chain retail, and identical suburban developments strip places of their authentic identity, creating "clone towns." Examples include identikit shopping centres, motorway service stations, and airport terminals.

Components of Place Identity (Agnew's Framework)

Political geographer John Agnew (1987) identified three fundamental components of place:

- **Location:** The geographical position of a place — its coordinates, accessibility, and spatial relationship to other places. Location shapes economic opportunity (proximity to markets, transport networks) and exposure to external influences
- **Locale:** The physical setting and material form of a place — its buildings, streets, landscape, infrastructure, and layout. The locale includes both the natural environment (topography, climate, vegetation) and the built environment (architecture, public spaces, land use)
- **Sense of place:** The subjective meaning and emotional connection people feel towards a place — shaped by lived experience, memory, social relations, and cultural identity. This is what makes a house feel like "home" or a neighbourhood feel like "my community"

Insider and Outsider Perspectives

Insider Perspective	Outsider Perspective
Lived, everyday experience of people who belong to the place and identify with it	Views of visitors, tourists, media, government, estate agents, and newcomers
Deep, experiential knowledge built over time; emotional connection	May be superficial, stereotypical, or based on limited encounters and representations
Identity shaped by daily routines, relationships, and personal memories	Influenced by representations in media, art, tourism marketing, and statistics
May not notice gradual changes (creeping normalcy)	May notice contrasts, differences, and distinctive features more readily
Can resist or resent external characterisations of their place	Can bring fresh perspectives and identify opportunities or problems insiders overlook

Exam Tip: OCR expects you to understand that places are socially constructed — different people experience and perceive the same place differently depending on their age, gender, ethnicity, class, sexuality, disability, and length of residence. An elderly white resident of a gentrifying neighbourhood will have a very different sense of place from a young professional newcomer or a

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recently arrived migrant. Use the terms "insider" and "outsider" explicitly, and always explain whose perspective you are describing.

Place Profiles: Demographic and Economic Characteristics

Quantitative Data for Place Profiles

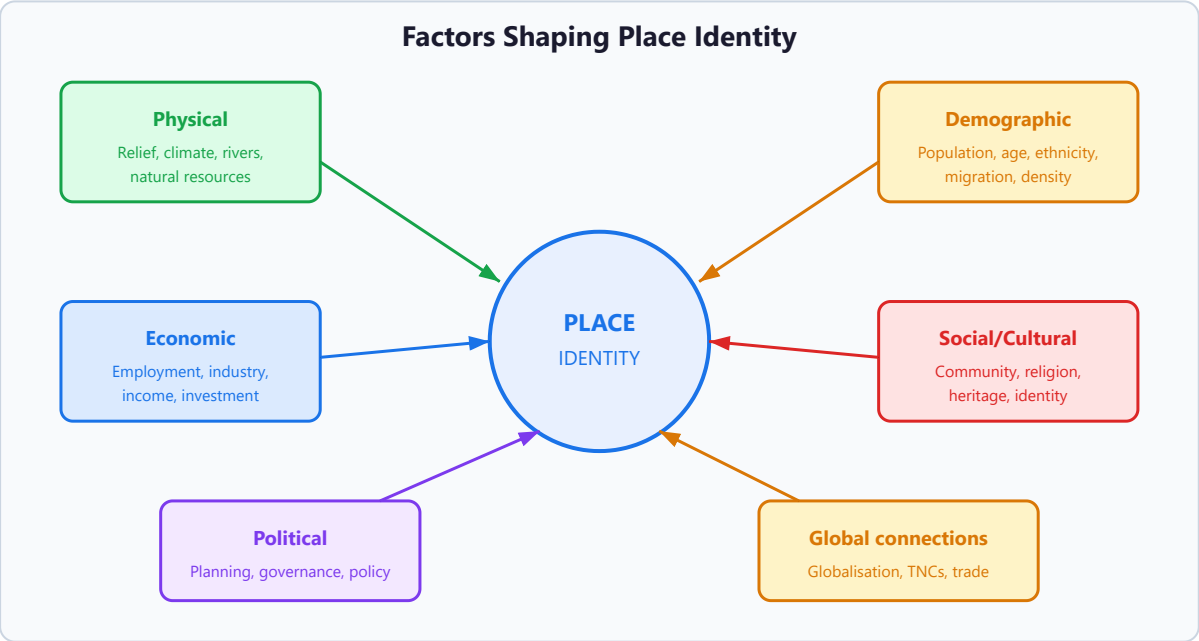
Place profiles use statistical data to describe and compare the measurable characteristics of places. Key indicators include:

- **Population size and density:** Total residents; people per km^2. Urban areas can exceed 5,000/km^2; rural areas may be <50/km^2
- **Age structure:** Proportion of young (<16), working-age (16–64), and elderly (65+) residents. Expressed as dependency ratios. Ageing populations (e.g., rural coastal towns) vs youthful populations (inner cities with students/migrants)
- **Ethnicity and cultural diversity:** Ethnic composition; proportion of foreign-born residents; languages spoken. E.g., Newham (east London) is one of the UK's most ethnically diverse boroughs: 71% non-white British, 100+ languages spoken
- **Employment structure:** Proportion in primary/secondary/tertiary/quaternary sectors. Clark-Fisher model shows long-term shift from primary to tertiary as economies develop. UK: ~1% primary, ~15% secondary, ~80% tertiary/quaternary
- **Income levels:** Average household income; Index of Multiple Deprivation (IMD — England's official measure of relative deprivation, combining 7 domains: income, employment, education, health, crime, barriers to housing, and living environment)
- **Housing:** Tenure (owner-occupied, private rented, social housing); house prices; housing type (detached, semi, terraced, flats); overcrowding indices
- **Health:** Life expectancy; infant mortality; obesity rates; mental health prevalence; access to healthcare. Life expectancy varies by up to 20 years between the most and least deprived areas in England
- **Education:** GCSE/A-Level attainment; university participation rates; % with no qualifications
- **Crime rates:** Recorded crime per 1,000 population by type (violent, property, antisocial)
- **Environmental quality:** Air pollution (PM2.5, NO_2); green space access; noise levels

Qualitative Data

Quantitative data alone cannot capture the lived experience of a place. Qualitative research methods are essential for understanding sense of place, identity, and community:

- **Semi-structured interviews:** In-depth conversations with residents about their experiences, memories, and perceptions
- **Oral histories:** Recording long-term residents' accounts of change over decades
- **Photographs and visual surveys:** Capturing the character and condition of the built and natural environment
- **Mental maps:** Asking residents to draw their area from memory reveals what they consider important and how they perceive boundaries
- **Participant observation:** Spending time in a place, observing daily life, interactions, and atmosphere
- **Art, literature, and music:** Creative representations reveal cultural attitudes and emotional attachments
- **Social media analysis:** Online reviews, geotagged posts, and community forums capture contemporary perceptions



How Places Change Over Time

Internal (Endogenous) Factors

Factors originating from within the place that shape its character and trajectory:

- **Physical geography:** Rivers, coastline, relief, climate, soil quality, natural resources. These often determined a place's original function (e.g., coal deposits created mining towns like Consett; river crossings created market towns like Oxford; natural harbours created port cities like Liverpool)
- **Land use:** Residential, commercial, industrial, agricultural zones and how they have evolved. The Burgess and Hoyt models describe idealised urban land-use patterns; real cities are more complex
- **Built environment:** Architecture, heritage buildings, infrastructure quality. Victorian terraces, brutalist tower blocks, and glass-fronted office buildings each tell a story about the era and values that produced them
- **Demographic characteristics:** Age structure, ethnicity, population density and how these change through natural change and migration
- **Local culture and community:** Traditions, social networks, religious institutions, community organisations, local dialect, food culture. These create a distinctive "social fabric" that defines the character of a place

External (Exogenous) Factors

Forces acting on a place from outside, often more powerful than endogenous factors in driving rapid change:

- **Globalisation:** Increased interconnectedness brings investment, migration, cultural exchange, and exposure to global markets — but also homogenisation, dependency, and vulnerability to external economic shocks
- **Government policy:** Planning decisions, enterprise zones, austerity measures, devolution, transport investment, housing policy, and welfare reform. Decisions made in Westminster or Brussels can transform or devastate distant communities (e.g., pit closures in the 1980s; austerity cuts to local government funding 2010–2020)
- **Transnational corporations (TNCs):** Investment decisions by large companies can transform local economies (e.g., Nissan in Sunderland created 7,000 direct jobs and 27,000 in the supply chain) or devastate them when they leave (e.g., Redcar steelworks closure, 2015: 3,000 job losses)
- **Migration:** Inward migration changes demographics, culture, linguistic landscape, and service demands. Outward migration can cause population decline, brain drain, and ageing (e.g., rural depopulation in the Scottish Highlands)
- **Technology:** Digital connectivity, automation, online retail, and remote working are restructuring the economy of every place. High streets decline as online shopping grows; technology hubs attract young,

skilled workers

- **Economic restructuring:** The shift from manufacturing to services (deindustrialisation) has been the single most transformative exogenous factor for many UK places since the 1970s

Changing Economic Structures

Deindustrialisation

Deindustrialisation: The decline of manufacturing industry in a region or country, typically accompanied by job losses, population decline, physical dereliction, and multiple forms of social deprivation. In the UK, manufacturing fell from 25% of GDP and 7.1 million jobs in 1970 to under 10% of GDP and 2.7 million jobs today. The causes include global competition (cheaper labour overseas), automation, government policy (Thatcherite economic reforms prioritised services over heavy industry), and the shift to a post-industrial economy.

The Shift to Service Economies and the North-South Divide

The UK has transitioned from a secondary (manufacturing) economy to a tertiary/quaternary (service/knowledge) economy. This has created stark geographical winners and losers, producing the so-called "North-South divide" — though the reality is more nuanced than this simple binary:

Winners	Losers
London and the South East (finance, tech, creative industries, professional services; London generates ~22% of UK GDP with ~13% of population)	Former industrial heartlands (North East, South Wales, Central Scotland, Lancashire cotton towns, Yorkshire steel towns)
Highly educated, skilled workers in knowledge economy sectors	Low-skilled manual workers whose industries disappeared; those without transferable skills
University cities (Oxford, Cambridge, Bristol, Edinburgh, Manchester) that attract graduate talent and R&D investment	Former mining/steel towns (Consett, Merthyr Tydfil, Barnsley, Easington) with persistent deprivation decades after industry closed

Places with good transport connectivity (especially to London)	Peripheral areas with poor transport links and limited broadband

Case Study: Detroit, USA — Deindustrialisation and Attempted Recovery

Detroit illustrates the most extreme consequences of deindustrialisation in a developed country:

- **Rise:** Centre of the American auto industry from the 1900s; home to Ford, General Motors, and Chrysler ("Motor City"). Population peaked at 1.85 million in 1950 — one of America's wealthiest cities. Assembly-line mass production (Fordism) created a large, well-paid working class
- **Decline:** Deindustrialisation began in the 1970s as automation replaced workers, Japanese competition (Toyota, Honda) undercut US manufacturers on quality and price, and companies relocated production to cheaper locations (Mexico, the US South). Suburbanisation drew wealthier residents (predominantly white) to surrounding suburbs ("white flight"), hollowing out the tax base and concentrating poverty
- **Scale of decline:** Population fell from 1.85 million (1950) to ~640,000 by 2020 (65% decline); 78,000 abandoned buildings; 40 square miles of vacant land; unemployment peaked at 28% during the 2008 recession. City filed for bankruptcy in 2013 ($18 billion in debt — largest municipal bankruptcy in US history)
- **Social consequences:** Poverty rate ~35% (3x national average); crime rates among highest in USA; 47% functional illiteracy among adults; racial inequality entrenched (78% Black population in the city vs predominantly white suburbs). Life expectancy in some neighbourhoods is 15 years lower than in nearby suburbs
- **Recent regeneration:** Downtown core has attracted tech startups, new restaurants, and Dan Gilbert's Quicken Loans (now Rocket Companies) investments ($5.6 billion in property). Midtown and Corktown neighbourhoods gentrifying. But benefits have not reached most residents — two-speed city with gleaming downtown surrounded by devastated neighbourhoods

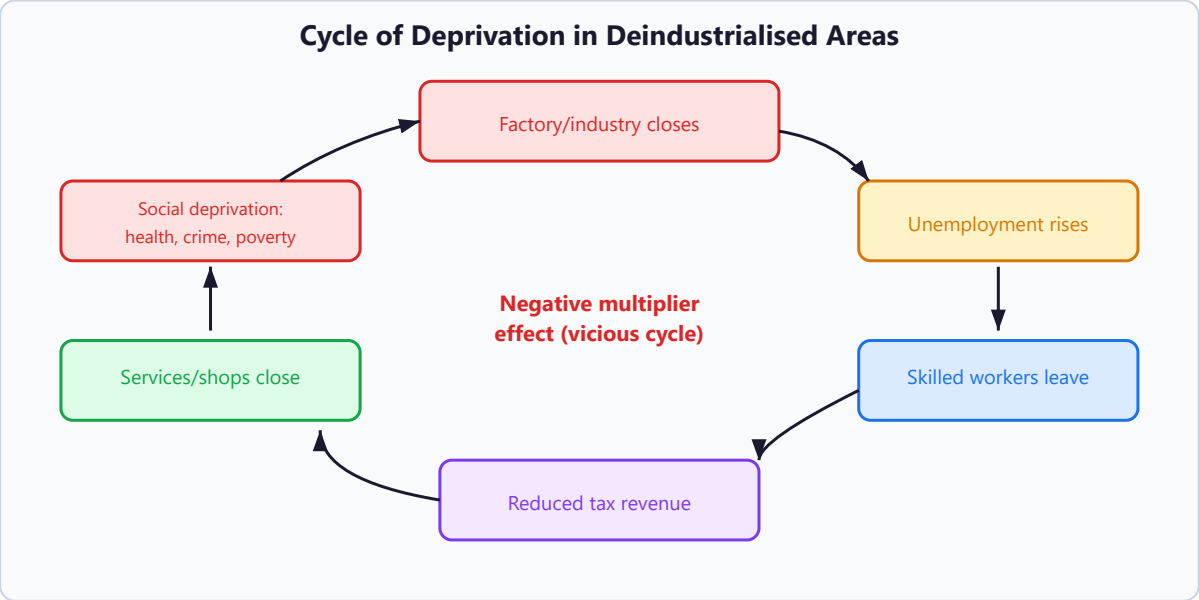
Globalisation and Place

Globalisation: The increasing interconnectedness of the world through trade, communication, migration, and cultural exchange, driven by advances in technology (internet, containerisation, air

travel) and facilitated by international agreements and organisations (WTO, IMF). It has accelerated dramatically since the 1980s.

Impacts of Globalisation on Places

- **Economic:** TNC investment creates jobs but also dependence on external decisions; offshoring moves manufacturing jobs to cheaper locations; global competition can destroy local industries (e.g., UK textiles, pottery). "Footloose" TNCs can relocate quickly, leaving communities stranded
- **Cultural:** Spread of Western (especially American) consumer culture — "McDonaldisation" and "Coca-Colonisation." Loss of local traditions, languages, and cuisines. But also: cultural diversity through migration creates vibrant multicultural places (e.g., Brick Lane, London; Balti Triangle, Birmingham)
- **Demographic:** International migration changes ethnic composition and age structures. Source areas lose young workers; destination areas become more diverse but face integration challenges
- **Environmental:** Increased consumption, carbon-intensive transport, and resource extraction. But also: global environmental agreements and the spread of green technology
- **Placelessness:** Globalisation creates "clone towns" — the New Economics Foundation found that 41% of UK towns were "clone towns" dominated by the same chain stores, with local independent retailers disappearing. Identical Starbucks, Primarks, and Tesco Metros replace local cafes, tailors, and grocers
- **Glocalisation:** Global brands adapt to local cultures (e.g., McDonald's serves McAloo Tikki in India, teriyaki burgers in Japan), showing that globalisation is not simply one-directional homogenisation



Representations of Place

How Places Are Represented

The way a place is portrayed affects people's perceptions and can differ greatly from lived reality. Representations are never neutral — they reflect the interests, values, and biases of whoever creates them:

- **News media:** Coverage often focuses on crime, deprivation, or spectacular events, creating stereotypes and stigmatising places. Areas like Moss Side (Manchester) or Jaywick (Essex) become defined by negative media attention, which can depress property values and discourage investment
- **Film and television:** Can romanticise or stigmatise places. "Gritty North" vs "affluent South" tropes in UK dramas. Tourism spikes after popular shows (the "Downton Abbey effect" on Highclere Castle; "Peaky Blinders" effect on Birmingham)
- **Marketing and place branding:** Tourism boards, councils, and developers actively promote positive images to attract investment, visitors, and residents. "I Amsterdam," "Visit Wales," "Glasgow: People Make Glasgow"
- **Art and literature:** Artists and writers shape enduring perceptions. Constable's paintings constructed a pastoral vision of rural Suffolk; Dickens' novels defined Victorian London's poverty; L.S. Lowry's matchstick figures represent industrial Lancashire
- **Social media:** User-generated content creates new, often curated and aspirational representations (Instagram-worthy places). But also allows marginalised voices to challenge dominant narratives
- **Statistics and data:** Census data, deprivation indices, and league tables provide quantitative representations. But: what is measured (and not measured) reflects political choices. The IMD can label a place as "deprived" in ways that residents contest
- **Maps and cartography:** What is included or excluded from maps is a form of representation. Historical maps reveal colonial perspectives; modern maps highlight or hide features depending on purpose

Formal representations: Official, institutional portrayals — census data, government reports, council marketing materials, planning documents, Ordnance Survey maps.
Informal representations: Everyday, grassroots portrayals — social media, graffiti, local newspapers, word of mouth, music, street art, personal blogs and vlogs.

Exam Tip: Always interrogate representations: Who created it? What was their purpose? What is included or excluded? Whose perspective does it reflect? Representations can be used to attract

investment (place branding), justify regeneration (emphasising deprivation), or reinforce stereotypes (sensationalist media). The most sophisticated answers discuss how representations have material consequences — they affect investment, policy, and people's willingness to live in or visit a place.

Place-Making and Regeneration

Regeneration: The investment in and renewal of areas that have experienced decline, aiming to improve economic, social, and environmental conditions. Can be government-led (top-down), private sector-led, community-driven (bottom-up), or a combination. The term "place-making" emphasises creating meaningful, functional, and inclusive places rather than simply physical redevelopment.
Rebranding: Changing the image and perception of a place through marketing, events, and physical transformation to attract new investment, residents, and visitors.

Types of Regeneration Strategy

Strategy	Description	Example
Flagship development	Large-scale, iconic project to attract investment and change perceptions through a "catalytic" effect	London 2012 Olympics; Guggenheim Museum, Bilbao (visitor numbers rose from 100,000 to 1.3 million in the first year — the "Bilbao effect")
Rebranding/reimaging	Changing the identity and perception of a place through marketing campaigns, cultural events, and narrative change	Glasgow: "People Make Glasgow" campaign after decades of association with poverty and violence; Sheffield: "Outdoor City" brand
Enterprise zones	Designated areas with tax breaks, reduced business rates, simplified planning, and infrastructure investment to attract businesses	London Royal Docks EZ; 48 EZs in England offering up to 100% business rate discount for 5 years

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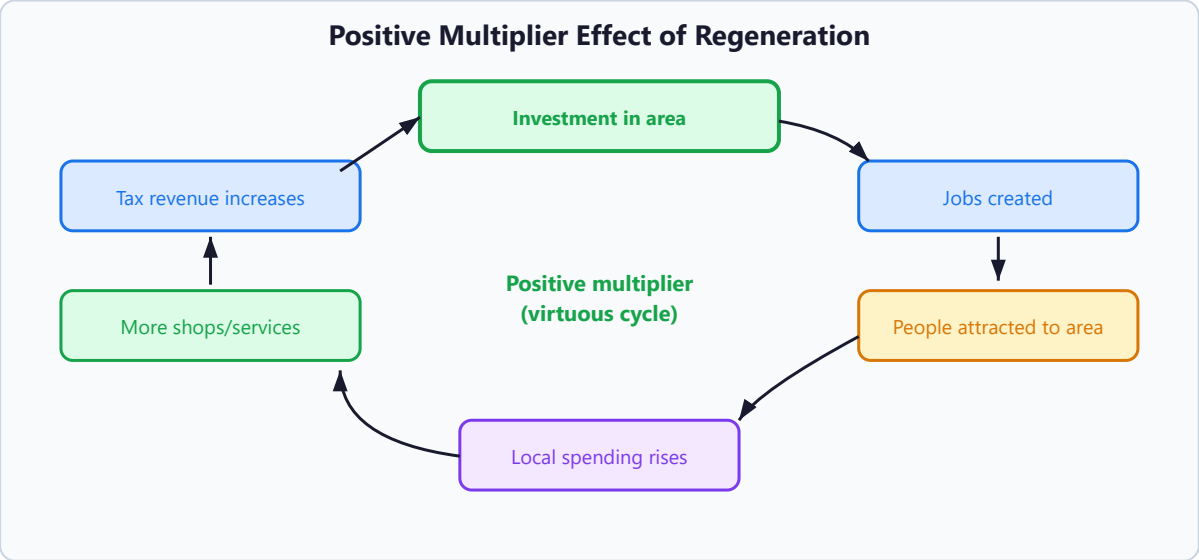
Infrastructure investment	Transport improvements to increase accessibility, connectivity, and attractiveness	HS2 (connecting London to Birmingham, then Manchester/Leeds); Crossrail/Elizabeth Line (added ~10% to property values within 1 km of stations)
Housing renewal	Demolition of poor-quality housing and construction of new, mixed-tenure developments	Park Hill, Sheffield (Grade II* listed brutalist estate, partially refurbished by Urban Splash with flats selling at 3x social housing values)
Cultural/creative regeneration	Using arts, culture, heritage, and creative industries to transform an area's identity and economy	Tate Modern, Bankside, London (former power station; 5.9 million visitors/year; catalysed regeneration of entire South Bank); Baltic, Gateshead
Community-led regeneration	Bottom-up initiatives driven by local residents and community organisations	Coin Street Community Builders, London (local residents fought off commercial developers in the 1980s; now run affordable housing, co-ops, and community facilities on the South Bank)



Case Study: Stratford, East London — Olympic Regeneration (Top-Down)

The 2012 Olympic Games was used as a catalyst for regeneration of one of London's most deprived areas:

- **Before 2012:** Stratford was characterised by contaminated brownfield land (former industrial sites), derelict rail yards, poor-quality social housing, high unemployment (~12%), low incomes (average household income 60% of the London average), poor health outcomes, and limited transport connectivity. The Lower Lea Valley was one of London's most deprived areas (bottom 10% nationally on the IMD)
- **Investment scale:** ~$9.3 billion spent on Olympic Park, transport infrastructure, and legacy developments. Over 2 million tonnes of contaminated soil remediated
- **Physical transformation:** Olympic Park converted to Queen Elizabeth Olympic Park (560 acres of parkland); Westfield Stratford City shopping centre (largest urban shopping mall in Europe, 300+ shops); Athletes' Village became East Village (2,800 homes); new schools (Chobham Academy), health centres, and cultural venues (London Stadium, Aquatics Centre, ArcelorMittal Orbit). Stratford International station (HS1) provided direct Eurostar connection to continental Europe
- **Positive outcomes:** 46,000+ new jobs created; 10,000+ new homes planned across the Olympic Legacy area; major transport improvements (DLR, Jubilee Line extensions, Overground, Crossrail/Elizabeth Line); new green spaces and biodiversity habitats; area's international profile transformed; UCL East campus bringing world-class university presence
- **Criticisms and negative impacts:** Gentrification displaced existing communities — house prices in E20 postcode rose ~80% between 2012 and 2020, pricing out original residents. Affordable housing target missed: only 30% delivered vs 50% originally promised, and definitions of "affordable" included homes at 80% of market rent (still unaffordable for many). Local independent businesses forced out by Westfield; allotments and traveller sites cleared. Allegations of "social cleansing" — regeneration primarily benefited developers and middle-class newcomers, not existing residents. The legacy corporation's board was dominated by business interests, not community representatives
- **Key lesson:** Flagship regeneration can transform the physical landscape and attract investment, but without deliberate policy to protect existing communities, benefits are captured by outsiders while original residents are displaced. The question "regeneration for whom?" is central

Case Study: Toxteth, Liverpool — Persistent Deprivation Despite Regeneration

- **Background:** Liverpool's docks closed progressively from the 1960s; manufacturing declined; deindustrialisation caused mass unemployment. The inner-city area of Toxteth (L8 postcode) experienced severe deprivation: high unemployment (40%+ at its worst), poor Victorian housing,

racial discrimination (large Black British and mixed-heritage population), and neglected infrastructure. Racial tensions and police harassment culminated in the 1981 Toxteth riots — 9 days of unrest causing $11 million in damage and prompting the Heseltine report on inner-city decline

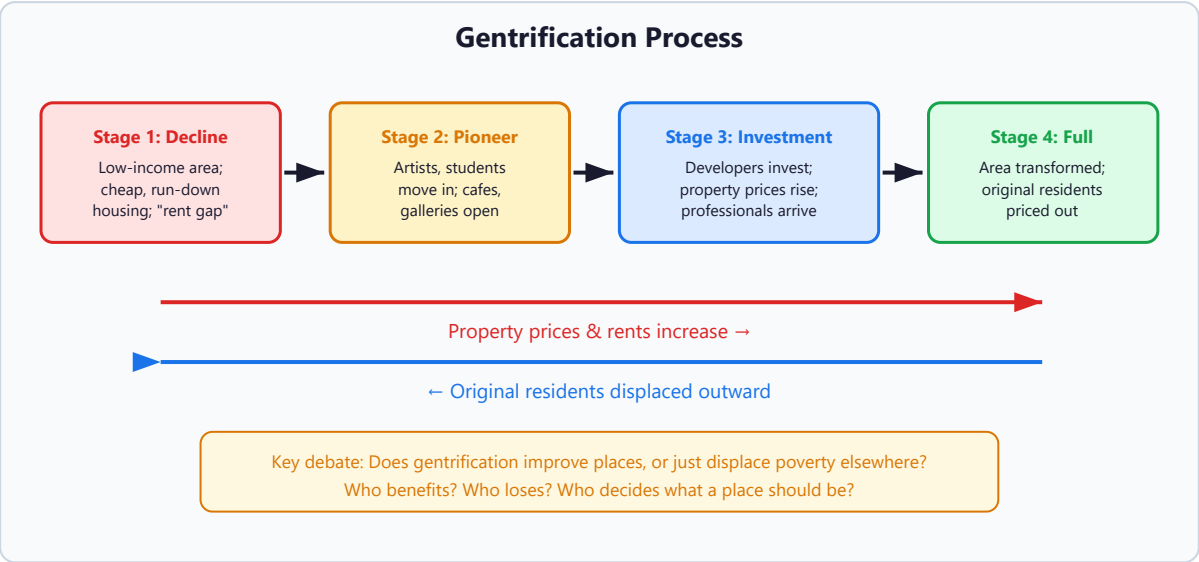
- **Regeneration attempts:** Michael Heseltine's "Minister for Merseyside" role led to investment in housing renewal and the International Garden Festival (1984). Liverpool European Capital of Culture 2008 (4.7 million visits; $800 million economic impact claimed). Liverpool ONE shopping centre ($1 billion, opened 2008). Waterfront regeneration: Albert Dock (Tate Liverpool, Beatles Story, hotels, restaurants). Baltic Triangle creative quarter. $5.5 billion "Liverpool Waters" development planned for the northern docks
- **Outcomes:** City centre transformed — tourism doubled between 2008 and 2019; visitor economy worth $4.9 billion/year. But: Toxteth (L8) itself remains among England's most deprived areas (bottom 1% on IMD for multiple domains). Benefits concentrated in the city centre and waterfront, not reaching surrounding residential areas. Gentrification in the Baltic Triangle has displaced artist communities who originally gave it character. Youth unemployment in Toxteth remains 3x the national average. Austerity (2010–2020) cut Liverpool City Council's funding by 63% in real terms, undermining public services and local government capacity
- **Key lesson:** Regeneration that focuses on physical redevelopment and tourism without addressing structural inequality (education, employment, health, discrimination) does not "trickle down" to the most deprived communities. Place-based economic strategies must be accompanied by people-based social investment

Conflict and Inequality in Place Change

Gentrification

Gentrification: The process by which a previously low-income, working-class neighbourhood is transformed by the arrival of wealthier residents, investors, and businesses, leading to rising property prices and rents, displacement of original residents, and fundamental changes in the social and cultural character of the area. The term was coined by sociologist Ruth Glass in 1964, describing changes in inner London where working-class quarters were invaded by the middle class.

Stages of Gentrification



Impacts of Gentrification

Positive	Negative
Physical improvement of buildings, streets, and public spaces	Displacement of low-income residents who can no longer afford rising rents (direct displacement) or feel alienated in a changed community (indirect displacement)
Reduced crime and antisocial behaviour in some cases	Loss of community identity, social networks, and cultural heritage; "character" that attracted gentrifiers is destroyed by their arrival
Increased local tax revenue for the council	Local independent shops, pubs, and markets replaced by upmarket chains, boutiques, and artisan coffee shops
Better services, amenities, and environmental quality	Social tension between newcomers and original residents; resentment and alienation
Rising property values benefit existing owner-occupiers	Increased inequality; poverty is not reduced but relocated to other areas ("spatial displacement of disadvantage")

Stakeholder Conflicts in Place Change

Place change inevitably creates tensions between different groups with competing interests:

- **Developers and property investors** seek to maximise profit — prefer luxury housing and commercial space over affordable provision. They lobby for planning permission and reduced affordable housing requirements
- **Long-term residents** want affordable housing, community facilities, continuity of social networks, and preservation of neighbourhood character. They may feel excluded from decision-making processes
- **Local government** balances economic growth objectives with social needs. Often dependent on developer contributions (Section 106 agreements, Community Infrastructure Levy) and may favour investment over community preferences under fiscal pressure
- **National government** sets the policy framework (planning regulations, housing targets, enterprise zones, devolution deals). Decisions made in Westminster affect places hundreds of miles away
- **Environmental groups** oppose development on green belt, floodplains, or heritage sites. Advocate for brownfield-first development and green infrastructure
- **New residents and businesses** may have different cultural expectations and consumption patterns, changing the character of high streets and community spaces

Exam Tip: Gentrification questions require balanced analysis. Avoid presenting it as simply "good" or "bad" — the examiner rewards nuanced argument. Consider: Who benefits? Who loses? At what scale are you analysing (individual household, neighbourhood, city)? What alternatives exist? The concept of the "rent gap" (Neil Smith) explains why gentrification occurs: the difference between current land value and potential value if redeveloped creates an economic incentive for investment. Doreen Massey's work reminds us that changes in one place are always connected to wider processes of globalisation, inequality, and power.

Your Local Place Study

Exam Tip: For the exam, you must be able to discuss TWO contrasting places in detail (your local place and one contrasting place). For each, you need:

- A comprehensive place profile using quantitative data (demographics, economics, deprivation indices from Census 2021, ONS Nomis, IMD 2019)
- How the place has changed over time and the reasons for change (link to endogenous and exogenous factors)

- How different people perceive and experience the place (insider vs outsider perspectives; variation by age, gender, ethnicity, class)
- How the place is represented in formal (statistics, planning documents, council publications) and informal (media, social media, art, literature) ways
- Evidence of connections to wider processes (globalisation, migration, government policy, deindustrialisation)
- Both qualitative (interviews, photographs, mental maps, observations) and quantitative evidence to support your points

The examiner rewards specific, place-based knowledge with precise data rather than generic statements. Know IMD rankings, population change figures, house price data, and employment statistics for your places. Use census ward-level data for maximum precision.

Key Theorists and Concepts

Thinker	Key Idea	How to Use in Essays
Yi-Fu Tuan (1974, 1977)	Coined "topophilia" (love of place). Distinguished between abstract space and meaningful place. Argued that places are created through experience — we come to know and value places by living in them	Use when discussing sense of place, emotional attachment, and the difference between quantitative descriptions of places and lived experience
Edward Relph (1976)	"Place and Placelessness." Warned that authentic place identity is being destroyed by mass culture, standardisation, and globalisation. Distinguished between "existential insideness" (deep belonging) and "existential outsideness" (alienation)	Use when discussing clone towns, the impact of globalisation on local identity, and placelessness in standardised retail and suburban environments

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Doreen Massey (1991, 2005)	"A Global Sense of Place." Argued that places are not fixed, bounded, or static — they are products of interconnections and flows. Places have multiple, contested identities shaped by power relations. A "progressive" sense of place is open, outward-looking, and shaped by connections, not walls	Use when discussing how globalisation, migration, and external forces shape local places; when critiquing nostalgia for a "lost" past; and when discussing multiple identities within a single place
David Harvey (1973, 2008)	Spatial justice; the "right to the city." Argued that capitalism creates uneven development between places, concentrating wealth in some areas while impoverishing others. The urban poor are denied the right to shape the cities they live in	Use when discussing inequality, gentrification, regeneration for profit vs regeneration for communities, and the political economy of place change
Ruth Glass (1964)	Coined the term "gentrification" while studying changes in inner London. Described how working-class quarters were progressively taken over by middle-class incomers	Use when defining and discussing gentrification; her original observation remains relevant to contemporary examples
Neil Smith (1979)	"Rent gap theory." Gentrification occurs when there is a gap between the current economic return from land and the potential return if the land were redeveloped. This gap creates an economic incentive for capital investment and displacement	Use when explaining why gentrification occurs in specific locations and not others; links gentrification to capitalism and investment decisions rather than individual lifestyle choices

Exam Tip: Referencing Massey, Tuan, Relph, or Harvey in your essays demonstrates conceptual depth and A/A*-level thinking. But do not just name-drop — explain how their ideas apply to your specific examples. For instance: "Massey's concept of a progressive sense of place helps explain how Brick Lane's identity is not diminished by Bangladeshi migration and hipster gentrification but is continuously remade through successive waves of connection." This shows you understand and can apply the theory, not just recall it.

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